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Sephardic and Mizrahi Groups Condemn Wiener's Genocide Claim

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A coalition of Sephardic and Mizrahi Jewish organizations issued a joint statement on Jan. 14 condemning California State Senator Scott Wiener (D-San Francisco) for saying Israel has committed genocide in Gaza and calling on him to resign as co-chair of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus.

"As Sephardic and Mizrahi communities across California, we condemn California Senator Scott Wiener's false accusation that Israel has committed genocide in Gaza," the statement said.

The statement was signed by 30 Years After in Los Angeles; Congregation Anshey Sfard in San Francisco; the Iranian American Jewish Federation in Los Angeles; JIMENA: Jews Indigenous to the Middle East and North Africa in San Francisco; Karaite Jews of America in San Francisco; and Magain David Sephardim Congregation in San Francisco.

"As co-chair of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, Senator Wiener's statement does not represent the views, values, and interests of California's Jewish communities," the statement said, adding that it came "at a time when Jewish Californians face unprecedented antisemitic violence and hate."

The California Legislative Jewish Caucus describes its mission as "serving as a Jewish voice for justice, equality, and progress within the California Legislature." There are 15 State lawmakers in the caucus.

The remarks that prompted the statement were delivered in a 90-second video posted by Wiener on X on Jan. 11, in which he spoke in the first person directly into the camera. The video can be viewed at https://x.com/Scott_Wiener/status/2010464312792404192. In three days, the clip was viewed 2.5 million times.

"For those of you who saw the debate clip from last week, I want to clarify that I do believe Israel has committed genocide in Gaza, and I want to explain why I hesitated at the debate," Wiener said. "For the past two years, I have harshly opposed Israel's escalations in Gaza, and I've used phrases like total destruction and catastrophic levels of death and moral stain. But I haven't used the word genocide, and I want to explain why."

For years, I've condemned Netanyahu and his extremist government and the devastation they've inflicted on Gaza. It's why I've been clear I won't support U.S. funding for the destruction of Palestinian communities. I've stopped short of calling it genocide, but I can't anymore. pic.twitter.com/71nIt6K527

— Senator Scott Wiener (@Scott_Wiener) January 11, 2026

Wiener then addressed the historical meaning of the term.

"As a Jew, I am deeply aware that the word genocide was created in the wake of the Holocaust, which was the industrial extermination of 6 million Jews," Wiener said. "For many Jews, associating the word genocide with the Jewish state of Israel is deeply painful, and frankly traumatic."

He then said he believed the term applied.

"But despite that pain and that trauma, we all have eyes, and we see the absolute devastation and catastrophic death toll in Gaza inflicted by the Israeli government," Wiener said. "And we all have ears, and we hear the genocidal statements by certain senior members of the Israeli government. And to me, the Israeli government has tried to destroy Gaza and to push Palestinians out, and that qualifies as genocide."

The Sephardic and Mizrahi organizations called on the California Legislative Jewish Caucus and the Jewish Public Affairs Committee of California to take action. "Accordingly, we call on the California Legislative Jewish Caucus and JPAC to formally demand the immediate resignation of Senator Wiener as Co-Chair of the Caucus," the statement said.

The statement also announced steps if Wiener remains in the role. "Until the Caucus removes Senator Wiener from his position as co-chair, we call on all Sephardic, Mizrahi, Persian and Israeli American organizations to cease participation in and partnerships with the Caucus," the statement said.

Founded in 2007, 30 Years After describes itself as an organization created "for and by Iranian-American Jewish young professionals." The organization also positions itself as a point of contact for other Jewish and civic institutions seeking engagement with the Iranian-American Jewish community. According to the statement, "effective immediately, 30 Years After is also withdrawing its membership from JPAC until further notice." (JPAC is a coalition of Jewish community organizations that advocates in Sacramento on behalf of the Jewish community, which they estimate to be 1.2 million.)

As of publication, there had been no public response from the California Legislative Jewish Caucus or its leadership addressing the Sephardic and Mizrahi statement. The caucus is co-chaired by Wiener and Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), with Assemblymember Dawn Addis (D-Monterey) and State Senator Josh Becker (D- Menlo Park) serving as vice-chairs. No one has issued a statement, either individually or as a caucus, responding to the call for Wiener's resignation.

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